Inside a Beehive: The Buzzing City

Name: ______________________ Date: ____________ Year 4 English — Reading

ACARA v9.0: AC9E4LY05

Learning Intention

I am learning to use comprehension strategies to interpret and analyse an informative text.

Success Criteria

- I can identify the main idea and supporting details.
- I can explain relationships described in the text.
- I can make inferences using evidence from the text.

Inside a Beehive: The Buzzing City

A beehive might look like a simple wooden box from the outside, but inside, it functions like a highly organised city — one with thousands of citizens, each with a specific job to do.

At the centre of every hive is the queen bee. She is the only bee in the colony that can lay eggs, and a healthy queen can lay up to 2,000 eggs in a single day. Without a queen, an entire colony cannot survive for long, since no new bees would be born to replace the ones that die.

Most of the bees in a hive are worker bees, and despite their name, all worker bees are female. Workers take on different jobs depending on their age. Younger workers clean the hive and feed the larvae, while older workers take on riskier jobs, such as guarding the hive entrance or flying out to collect nectar and pollen from flowers.

Male bees, called drones, have only one job: to mate with a queen from another colony. Drones do not collect food, defend the hive, or make honey — and interestingly, they don't even have stingers.

Bees build their hive using hexagon-shaped cells made of beeswax, forming a honeycomb. The hexagon shape is no accident — it is the most efficient shape for storing the maximum amount of honey while using the least amount of wax.

Bees are also essential to humans. As they travel from flower to flower collecting nectar, they carry pollen with them, which helps plants reproduce. This process, called pollination, is critical for growing much of the fruit and vegetables we eat.

Part A — Comprehension Questions

Q1. How many eggs can a healthy queen bee lay in a day? ______

Q2. What gender are all worker bees? ______

Q3. True or False: Drone bees have stingers. ______

Q4. What shape are the cells in a honeycomb, and why is this shape used?

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Part B — More Comprehension Questions

Q5. Describe how a worker bee's job changes as it gets older.

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Q6. What is the one job of a drone bee?

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Q7. Explain what pollination is and why it matters to humans, using the text.

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Part C — Challenge: Think Deeper

> *A beekeeper notices that a hive's queen bee has died and no new queen has been raised to replace her.*

Q8. Using evidence from the text, predict what will eventually happen to this hive if nothing changes.

Q9. Explain why the text compares a beehive to 'a highly organised city.' Do you think this comparison is a good one? Justify your answer with evidence.

Q10. If all the bees in the world disappeared, explain what effect this could have on human food supplies, based on what the text says about pollination.

Answer Key — Part A & B

A1: Up to 2,000 eggs.

A2: Female.

A3: False — drone bees do not have stingers.

A4: Hexagon-shaped cells; this shape is the most efficient for storing the maximum honey while using the least wax.

A5: Younger workers clean the hive and feed larvae, while older workers take on riskier jobs like guarding the entrance or collecting nectar and pollen.

A6: To mate with a queen from another colony.

A7: Pollination is when bees carry pollen between flowers as they collect nectar, helping plants reproduce — this matters to humans because it is critical for growing much of the fruit and vegetables we eat.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: Without a queen to lay eggs, no new bees will be born to replace the ones that die, so the colony's population will shrink over time and the hive will eventually die out.

C9: Accept reasoned answers either way — supporting evidence includes the hive having different 'citizens' with specific roles (queen, workers, drones) working together for the colony's survival, similar to how a city has different jobs and roles that keep it functioning.

C10: Without bees, far less pollination would occur, meaning many fruits and vegetables that rely on bee pollination would struggle to grow, potentially leading to major food shortages for humans.